City of Cambridge

Community Development Department

Massachusetts Avenue & Cambridge Street Active Use Policy Order

Ordinance Committee Meeting

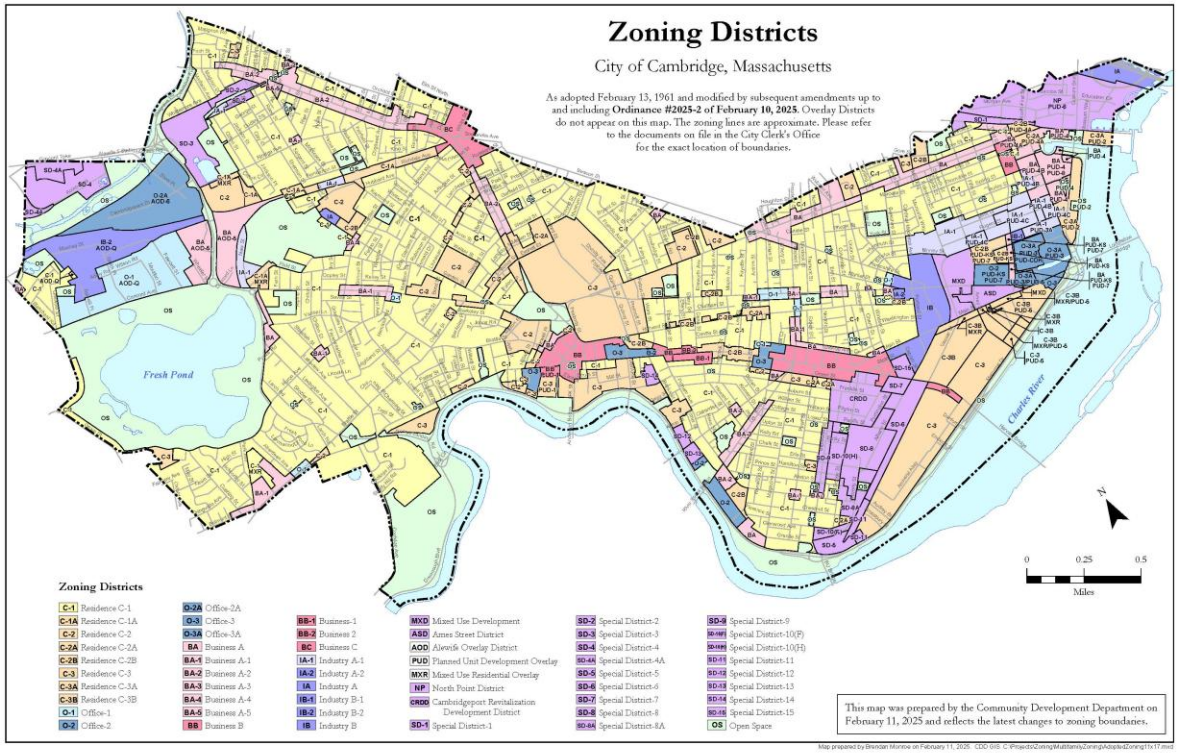
March 11, 2026

CITY OF CAMBRIDGE | CDD Community Development

POR 2025 #164

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to direct the Community Development Department (CDD) and Law Department to **prepare a draft of a separate zoning petition to strengthen Active Use requirements on Cambridge Street and the Porter Square PUD subdistricts** for sites that redevelop as single parcels.

Background: Multifamily Zoning Amendment



- Adopted Feb. 2025
- Biggest housing reform in 100 years
- Multifamily housing allowed as-of-right citywide
- Up to 4 stories allowed in all neighborhoods, 6 stories with inclusionary housing
- **Mixed-use districts allow 6-10 stories of housing or more**
- No minimum lot size or limits on units
- Reduced setback requirements

Mass Ave + Cambridge Street Rezoning

Adopted Dec. 2025 / Jan. 2026

- Implements the recommendations of the *Mass Ave Planning Study* (2025) and *Our Cambridge Street Study* (2023).
- **Allows up to 6 stories of housing throughout Cambridge Street and 12 stories on Mass Ave.**
- Allows up to 10 stories of housing in Lechmere and 12 stories in the Webster/Windsor area.
- Allows up to 18 stories of housing in Porter Square in exchange for public open space and retail concentration.
- **Incentivizes active ground floor uses like retail and restaurants.**
- Establishes design standards to encourage visually appealing buildings and a vibrant streetscape.



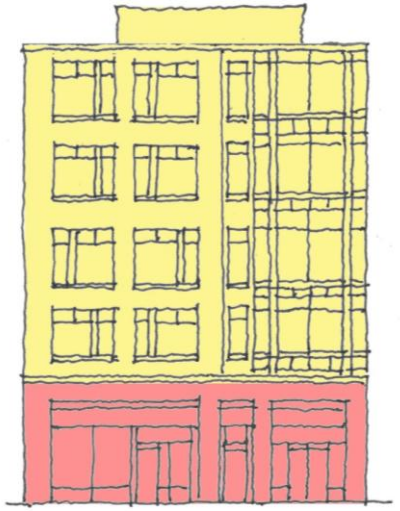
Ground Story Active Uses

Active Uses required for buildings above a certain height.

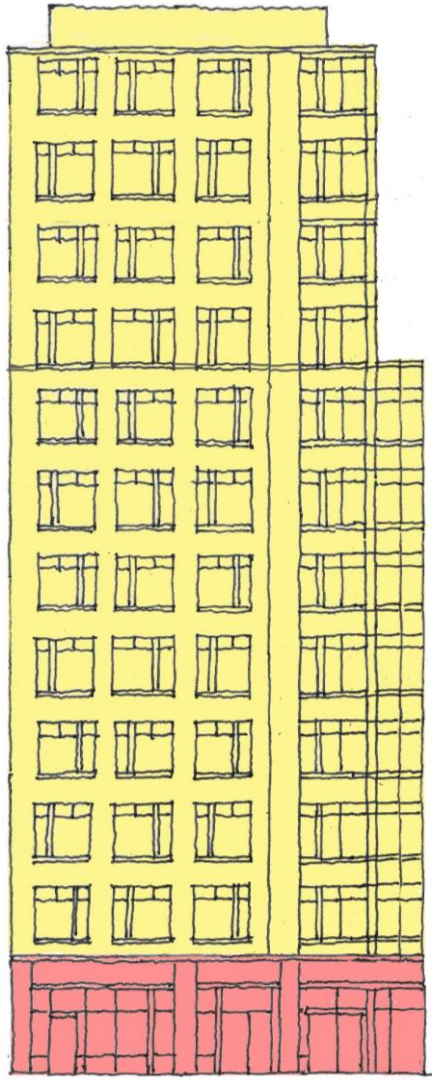
Current requirement for part of Mass Ave.



4 stories residential-only



5 stories residential with active ground story use



12 stories residential with active ground story use

Ground Story Active Uses

Why require active uses only above a certain height?

- Most new development will want to unlock taller heights (6 stories or more).
- Flexibility for more unique sites and cases where height is not the main goal (e.g., rehab/enlargement).
- Prevent creating new nonconformities for existing all-residential buildings.
- Forcing commercial space where infeasible can lead to undesirable outcomes (e.g., vacancies, unreasonable rents, or making any redevelopment infeasible).

Ground Story Active Uses

Active Uses include:

- **All institutional uses** including daycares, libraries, community centers.
- **Some office uses** like a dentist's office, accountant's office, or insurance agency. This does NOT include general offices, banks, or labs.
- **All retail and consumer services uses.**

















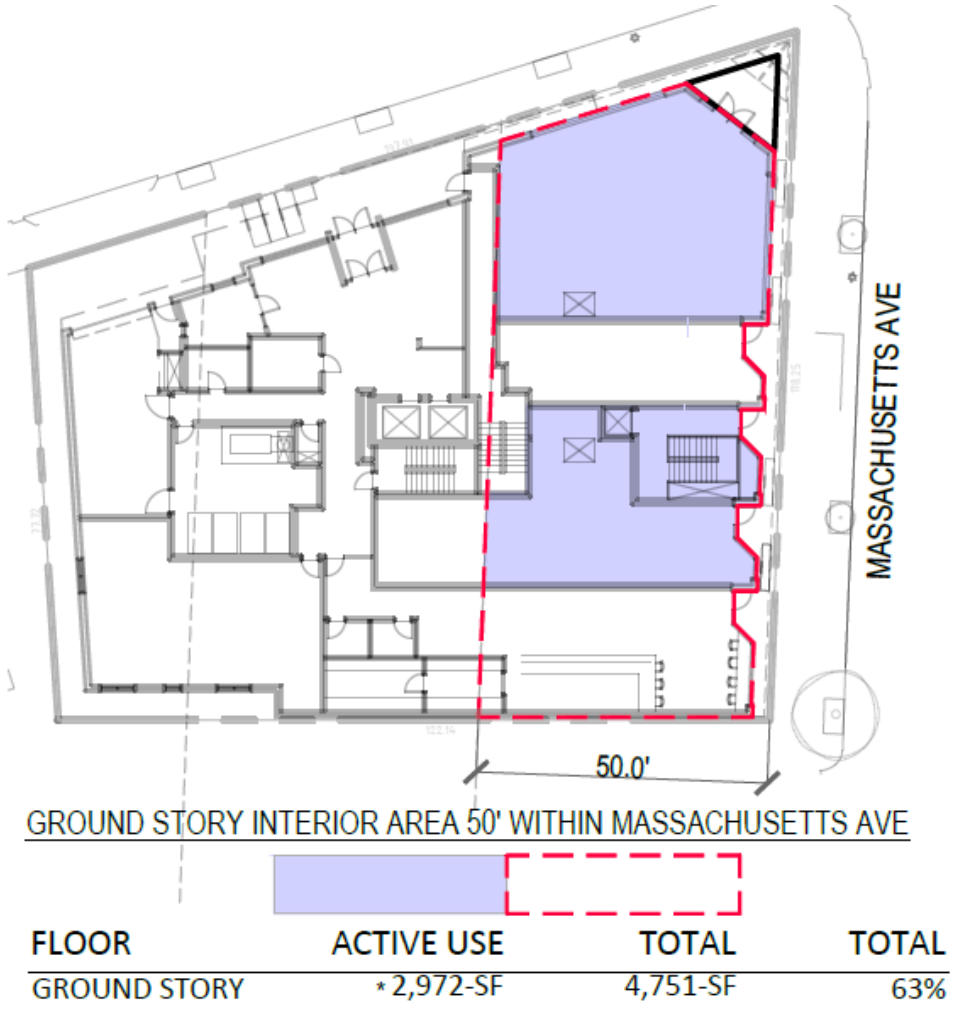
Active Use Floor Area Modifications

Floor Area Standards:

- 60% of interior floor area within 50’ of the street

Proposed Modifications by Special Permit:

- Planning Board can approve modifications if the intent is being met, such as:
  - Additional non-residential uses
  - Minor changes in amount and/or location of active use

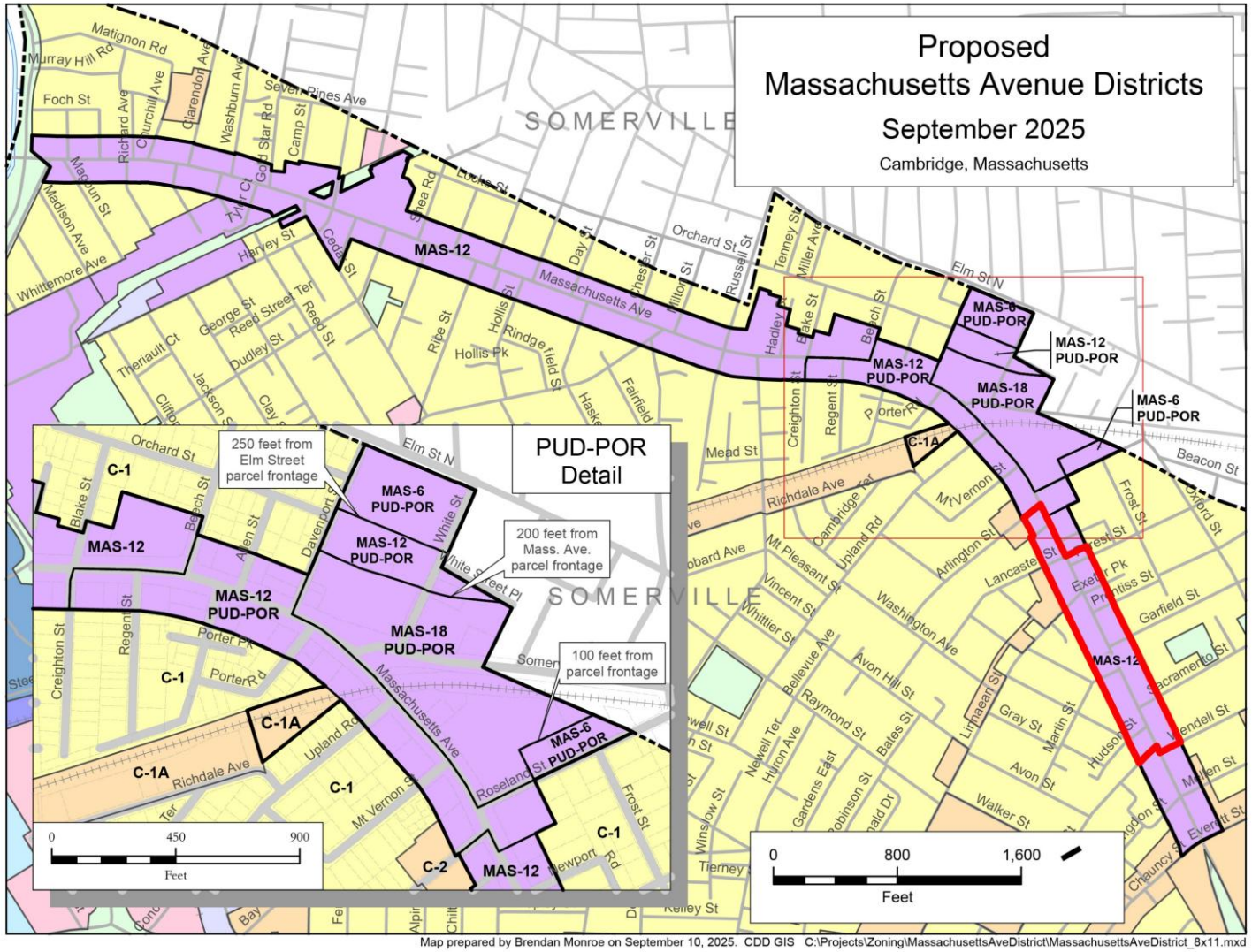


Existing Mass Ave

Active Uses required for buildings above a certain height.

Mass Ave:

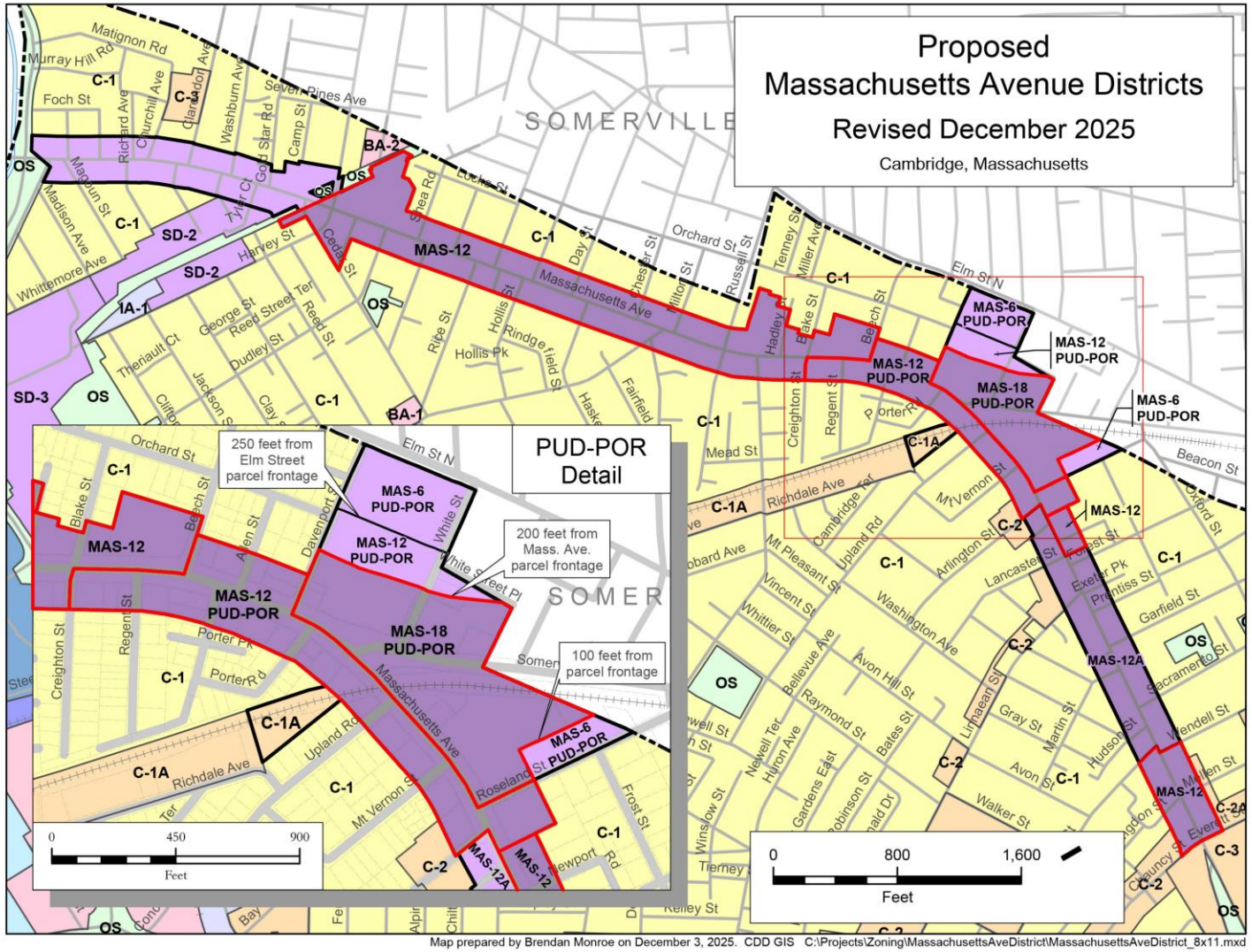
- Greater than 4 stories south of Porter Square
- Greater than 8 stories everywhere else



Mass Ave Recommendations

Require Active uses for buildings greater than 4 stories From Cambridge Common to Linear Park.

- Expand MAS-12A
- Active uses required for buildings greater than 4 stories in MAS-18



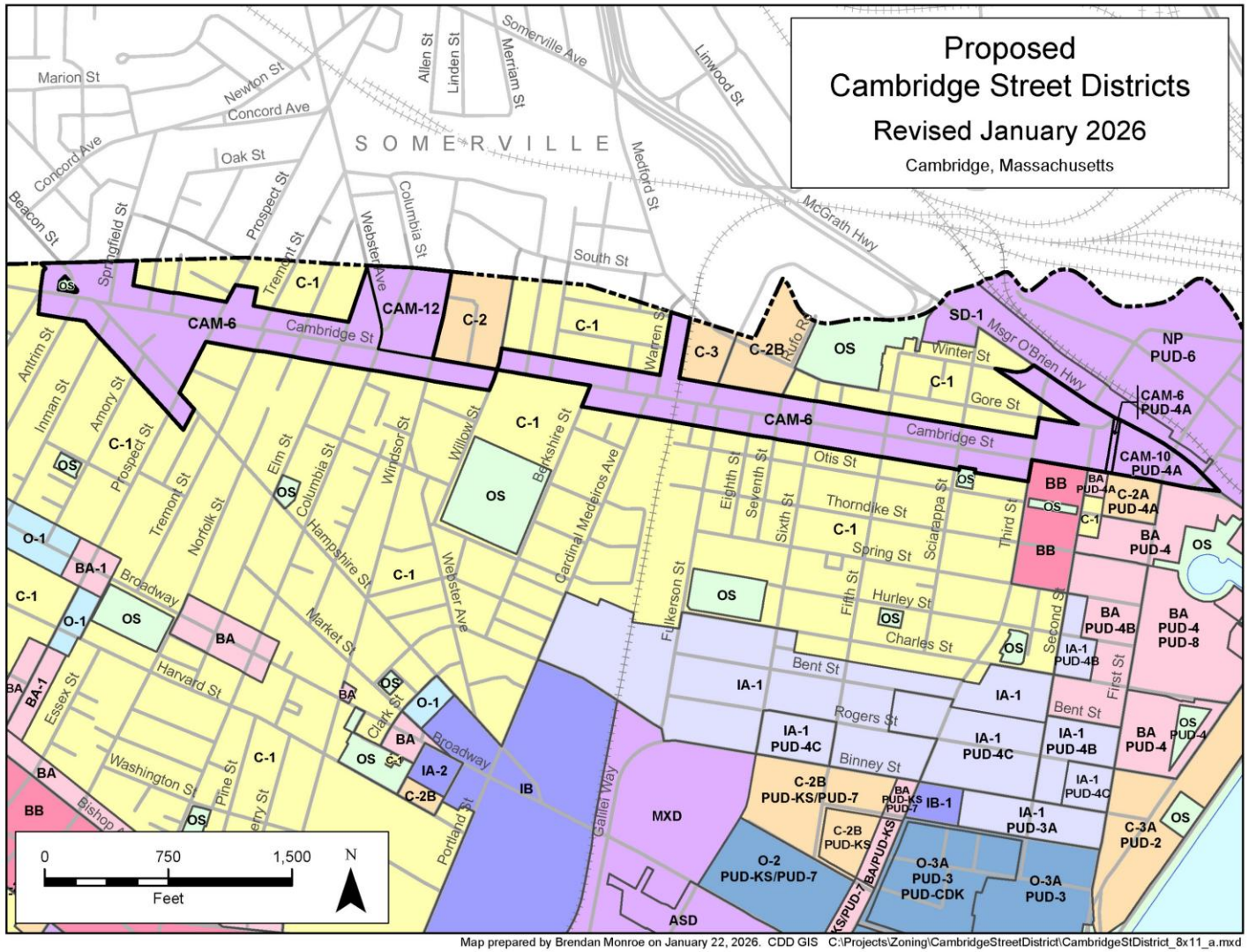
Existing Cambridge Street

Active Uses required for buildings above a certain height.

Cambridge St:

- Greater than 6 stories in Lechmere (CAM-10) and Webster/Windsor (CAM-12)

*Previous zoning (BA) allowed up to 6 stories with no active use requirement - same as new CAM-6 zoning.



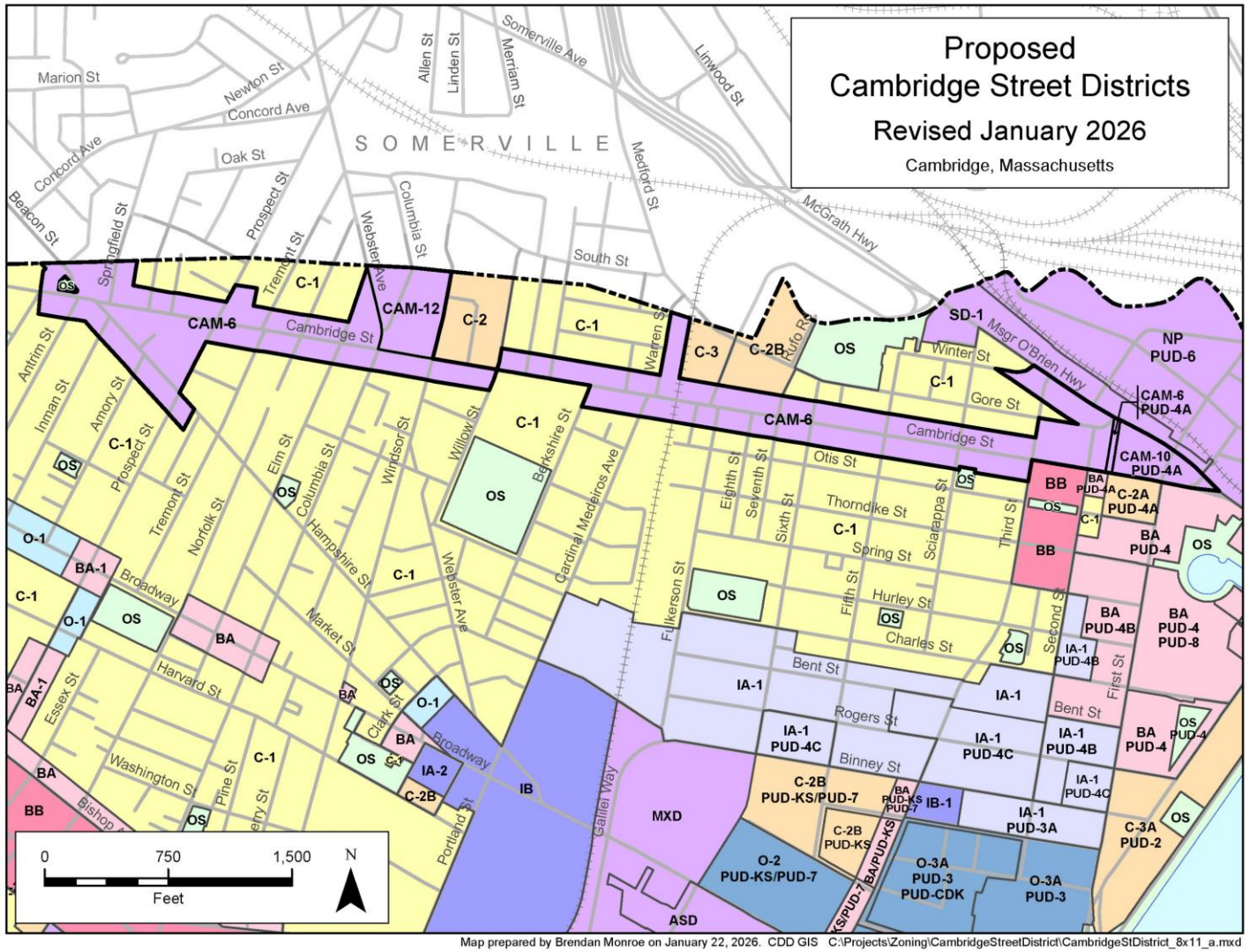
Cambridge Street Recommendations

Option 1: Same as Mass Ave

- Active uses required above 4 stories in all CAM districts.

Option 2: Stronger

- Active uses required above 3 stories in all CAM districts.



Considerations

In both scenarios, it is likely that most development will provide active uses in order to build to 6 stories.

Option 1

- Some 4-story residential without active use where 6-story mixed-use buildings are infeasible.
- **More housing, possibly less active use.**

Option 2

- Could be some 3-story residential where 6-story mixed buildings are infeasible, but redevelopment is less likely altogether.
- **Less housing, possibly more existing active use space is preserved but not guaranteed.**